of the world. Depending on the country concerned, it is perceived by them as an innovator, producer, contributor or exemplar. Each one of these attributes make it a more attractive partner in international relations.

Developing the boldness and fortitude to advance one's prospects is almost as hard as growing actual capabilities. Learning to compete at increasingly higher levels does require confident leadership and systemic changes. As stakes get higher, it is also necessary to outthink competitors and outlast mindgames. Each phase in a power's rise has different benchmarks and changing peer groups. Adjusting our ambitions and calculations constantly will never be easy. In India's case, we have steadily outgrown the hyphenation with Pakistan and are being increasingly perceived as sui generis.

A part of the challenge is also to strike the right understandings on the optimal terms with the most appropriate partners. How to get the give-and-take right is crucial. These could be in a field of commerce and investment or indeed in domains like technology and connectivity. There are always opportunities to leverage if a nation plays to its strengths. Similarly, it has additional possibilities that could emerge from global demands of reliable supply, trusted data or critical technologies.

That said, we cannot be oblivious either to structural obstacles created by a world order devised more than 75 years ago. The heart of the matter is that in those crucial years, India was either present nominally on the high table or not there at all. Especially because of what happened to it in 1947, India consequently operates in a world where the dice is often loaded against it. Indeed, its rise in the last seven decades is really a story of changing the terms of engagement with the world, many of which were particularly adverse when it started this journey.

The problem is not one that can be quantified economically; it is even more that of assumptions and narratives. The world order consists of institutions and practices that are often closely interlocked. They determine what is politically correct and what is not. And because its key players have not only built an architecture to serve their purpose but still retain the influence to promote it, a power like India will have to swim upstream for a long time to come. Among the most formidable currents it has to navigate are the challenges emanating from 'freezing the moment'. This is a widely practised stratagem by hegemonic powers that seek to make permanent the advantageous elements of a landscape.